

Judgment Restored Through Fullness, Mercy, and Self-Judgment

Open to the fifth chapter of Acts again. Hallelujah. And when we begin, it will be with that first verse again.

Let me lay the foundation for this again.

Precious Holy Spirit, our desire is to learn. You are the Teacher, so guide us into this. For this we give You the praise, honor, and glory.

And everybody said, "Amen."

All right. Let me see if I can remember to pick on different people.

Sister Mary, one of the most frightening accounts in the whole New Testament is what happened to Ananias and Sapphira and the way they died. What makes this so scary is that you and I know of ministries guilty of exactly the same things, yet they seem to have suffered no particular judgment for their actions.

And if that is not enough, sometimes we think only preachers are accountable enough to be judged that way. Yet Ananias and Sapphira were not exactly preachers. They were part of the congregation itself.

In fact, the verses that carry the account of what happened to Ananias and Sapphira are probably one of the worst nightmares for teachers who love to teach the books of the Bible verse by verse. And for those who love to teach the Bible by subjects, Ananias and Sapphira is a subject often avoided.

So let us take a look at these controversial verses for a moment, the account of what happened to Ananias and Sapphira in Acts 5:1-11:

But a certain man named Ananias, with Sapphira his wife, sold a possession,
And kept back part of the price, his wife also being privy to it, and brought a certain part, and
laid it at the apostles' feet.

But Peter said, Ananias, why hath Satan filled thine heart to lie to the Holy Ghost, and to
keep back part of the price of the land?

Whiles it remained, was it not thine own? And after it was sold, was it not in thine own
power? Why hast thou conceived this thing in thine heart? Thou hast not lied unto men, but
unto God.

And Ananias hearing these words fell down, and gave up the ghost: and great fear came on
all them that heard these things.

And the young men arose, wound him up, and carried him out, and buried him.

And it was about the space of three hours after, when his wife, not knowing what was done,
came in.

And Peter answered unto her, Tell me whether ye sold the land for so much? And she said,
Yea, for so much.

Then Peter said unto her, How is it that ye have agreed together to tempt the Spirit of the
Lord? Behold, the feet of them which have buried thy husband are at the door, and shall
carry thee out.

Then fell she down straightway at his feet, and yielded up the ghost: and the young men
came in, and found her dead, and carrying her forth, buried her by her husband.

And great fear came upon all the church, and upon as many as heard these things.

Then verse 12 says:

And by the hands of the apostles were many signs and wonders wrought among the people;
and they were all with one accord in Solomon's porch.

And it continues:

And of the rest durst no man join himself to them: but the people magnified them.
And believers were the more added to the Lord, multitudes both of men and women.

Like most preachers, I have an excellent set of Greek books to access the original language.
Unfortunately, sometimes the Greek tells the story just as generically as the King James does and
gives no particular insight as to why judgment would come on Ananias and Sapphira so severely
over something most preachers would esteem trivial or insignificant, such as lying in some
services.

Most commentators console themselves with words like "special acts of God," not knowing how to reconcile what happened to Ananias and Sapphira with the morals of the modern-day church. The general conclusion of most commentaries is that they were set forth as some kind of special example, a sort of one-time judgment.

But if this is the case, what have we learned? Greed among ministers is at an all-time high. There seems to be no fear among a growing number of preachers who represent the gospel. They seem to think the sheep's whole lives rise or fall according to what they are giving into their ministries, and many times it is quite evident their primary goal is not the gospel, but the pleasures of this life.

So, Mary, what happened to Ananias and Sapphira? Were these just special acts of God? Was God performing in such a way as to strike fear into the hearts of the Jews because He was favoring them and was contending to get them saved?

Will God perform for us Gentiles the same way He does for the Jews?

The answer is yes. He most emphatically will. This is why Peter said what he did in Acts 10:34-35:

Then Peter opened his mouth, and said, Of a truth I perceive that God is no respecter of persons:

But in every nation he that feareth him, and worketh righteousness, is accepted with him.

So, Mary, it is impossible for God to be a respecter of persons. That means He will do everything He can to save the people of one generation as He will another. What God did in the book of Acts, He would do in a moment for our generation if He could find what He needed to do it with, because God is no respecter of persons.

I am not just talking about killing people, either. I am talking about the signs and wonders that confounded the book of Acts generation, and also the fullness of the mantle that was on the apostles, in particular Peter and later the apostle Paul. And I know there had to be many more just like them.

The mantle I am talking about is how God used them to speak judgment, in fact instantaneous judgment.

Just to jump ahead for a moment, the primary qualifying factor to speak this kind of judgment is the mercy that rejoices against judgment, as James 2:13 says:

For he shall have judgment without mercy, that hath shewed no mercy; and mercy rejoiceth against judgment.

This is a primary qualification for judgment.

Last week we settled an issue after covering a couple of moves that were in fullness of mantle and manifestation in the early church, such as the fullness of the workings of miracles and gifts of healings, when they brought all the people who were demon possessed and sick from the cities round about.

The only way I can visualize that is not Broken Arrow and Jenks and Sapulpa. If I am hearing that everybody is getting healed, I am envisioning things like Houston and Kansas City and Oklahoma City.

Can you imagine the status of the church today if every demon-possessed person was laid in an arena somewhere, and every sick person, and twelve apostles walked out and just emptied the whole arena?

I mean, we would have an uproar. And that is exactly what they had.

On the day of Pentecost, the first who were born again, baptized, and added to the number were the three thousand Jews who heard what had happened in the upper room. These were devout Jews from every nation under the sky. They heard, received, and were baptized.

Then something happened. They sat at the feet of the twelve. Before the day of Pentecost, Judas was replaced with Matthias. Twelve men had slept with Jesus, eaten with Him, walked with Him, talked with Him, and heard every single teaching He did and every parable.

Now we have three thousand Jews sitting under such an anointing that they were of one mind, one soul, one heart, one accord. For three thousand Jews at one time to esteem their own possessions as not their own is some kind of miracle, especially when the love of money is the root of one third of the evil in the world.

How much? Are you starting to understand what kind of miracle that was?

So we have two moves at their fullness: the fullness of the mantle of the workings of miracles and gifts of healings, and the fullness of the mantle of joy and love for the brethren in one heart, one mind, and one purpose.

Then another major miracle happened. A man over forty years old, who had begged at the gate called Beautiful, at Solomon's porch, was running, jumping, leaping, and praising God. By the time the Jews were done cross-examining Peter and holding him overnight, five thousand more were added that day, not counting those who were being added daily as they fellowshiped from house to house, breaking bread and getting people saved.

We do not know how many thousands were saved and entering into that fellowship of one accord.

I have not seen anything like that. Once in a while a cult will come up and take everything you have, like the Jim Jones cult and David Koresh. But they were not knitted together because of love. They were knitted together because of fear and witchcraft.

Peter and all of them did not preach, "Bring all your belongings here." That was the kind of joy and purpose they had to see the King and the promise come to pass in their generation, and to be born again and filled with His power.

No wonder churches are lacking.

We have not seen that since. I cannot remember anything in history, except what has been documented in the Word of God, that has been that powerful.

But I plan to see it. I plan to see it again.

If those two things were in fullness of manifestation - the joy that was the strength of the love they walked in, singleness of purpose, and then the other mantle - oh, goodness.

Can you imagine all your demon-possessed relatives coming home whole? Can you imagine miracles so profound that they staggered the roughest of the Jews into surrendering? Can you imagine that?

Those two mantles were at their fullness, which we have not really seen since. But there was one more mantle at its fullness that we have not seen since. That was the mantle of judgment.

We do not understand too much about it because we do not understand too much about the other two. But when they come to their fullness, you can rest assured, so will the other.

You sound like you are happy about it.

Let me tell you why I am. There will be a lot fewer people in hell because of it, including usually the person who was judged.

How about the gospel of inclusion? I told you a couple of years ago, when He had me preach for three days on a coalition that would form to get the immoral vote, I told you who would start getting a voice.

And then to have another preacher who is real well known stand up and preach, "Do not pray for the Jews to be saved. You can pray for Israel, but do not pray for them to be saved. They have a covenant. They already are."

Now, tell me. When Carlton first did what he did, I did not want to mention his name. But if he is going to use me like that, I am supposed not to be afraid of persecution.

Well, you know what? I could care less anymore. I only have one purpose, one goal. I could care less.

But tell me, what do you think Peter would do? What do you think Paul would do when all of a sudden someone is preaching this under the banner of the gospel of Jesus Christ? What do you think they would do?

Hymenaeus and Alexander were doing something similar. Paul turned them over to the devil so that they might learn not to blaspheme or speak injuriously against the foundation of the church and take it away.

When that judgment is done publicly, it is because you can hear God. Then everybody who was taken by it gets to see what happened. How many know it would be better for all those who think they are saved but are not? And it would have been better for Carlton to have God face him on his deathbed than not at all.

Why did God judge Ananias and Sapphira? We did get there in time to prove they made it to heaven. But I noticed that some of those He judged needed time to repent to make it to heaven.

Nevertheless, Ananias and Sapphira made it to heaven.

Here is one of the reasons He could judge them. When you have ten, twelve, or fifteen thousand Jews in one accord, and they consider not their possessions their own, and they have one heart and one purpose - when you have that many walking together and that sold out - then you have a fullness of the love of God and the joy working there.

For Ananias and Sapphira to be judged as severely as they were on this side of the fence, it was not without their getting a taste of the fullness of the mantle of the love of God, and it was the best He had. It was not without them watching miracle after miracle after miracle.

So when they stepped forward and began to introduce that into the foundation of the church, which shortly after that every Jew would be carrying into every nation when Paul came in and ran them out, all God did was say, "Look, you are not going to introduce that now. Why don't you just come on home with Me?"

And they gave up the ghost.

God has to have somebody who can minister judgment. The problem is, He usually does not, because mercy rejoices against it. Most preachers I have seen try to administer any kind of judgment were doing it out of their own personal vendetta. Somebody did them wrong.

It will not work.

Nevertheless, I think when I was in Brazil, there was a pastor's wife. When I said I wished I had time to teach on Ananias and Sapphira, I also said, "Well, at least they went to heaven."

Somebody told me later that she said, "He cannot know that."

Oh, yes, he can. If God was performing judgment, He would do so more to get the person He is judging to come to heaven, and to bring everybody to heaven that person is getting out of the will of God.

So did they? Yes.

That is when we went over to Corinthians. Paul said no other foundation can be laid but what he had laid: Jesus Christ crucified. In this building of God, Jesus Christ being the chief cornerstone, Paul said there is no other foundation than what he had laid, Jesus Christ crucified. So take heed how you build upon that foundation. If you build hay, wood, stubble, or precious metals, there is going to be a day that tries it as by fire: the day of the Lord.

The way you purify gold is by burning the dross out of it.

So here you are. You preached your whole life against the Holy Spirit and speaking with tongues. You are a good, eternal kind of person. He says everything you preached and everything you did will be tried as by fire.

Thank God for His mercy, because the final judgment and His mercy follow us to the trash burning. Thank God for it, because He says if everything you did was burned, yet you had your salvation, you will be saved as by fire. It will all burn and be laid on Him as a final judgment, but because you still had the foundation intact, you yourself will go on to heaven rewardless.

But at least you will go. Amen.

Now, all Ananias and Sapphira did was something real trivial. I could name you five men of God probably right now who lied majorly over money, and they are still alive. There are horror stories about how they ripped the money out and threw the requests in the trash bin because it was a depositing outfit. There are horror stories all over.

I have been overseas where somebody raised a million dollars for them. I said, "Well, what did you get?"

They said, "Thirty thousand."

Gee, they had to pay the help a lot, didn't they?

They are still alive. Would God send somebody to hell over something that trivial? That is lying. How about teaching everybody your whole life not to receive the Holy Spirit? Seems to me they ought to be slapped around first. Yet that is all burned, and they make it.

Why would you think that just because the judgment was instantaneous they went to hell?

Hallelujah, Jesus.

But you have to remember this: when God is able to reinstate the mantle of judgment, it will be because the church has come back to that place in God again, not because He was doing special miracles in some generation because hell was hotter. He would do the same in every generation if He had something to do it with.

He does not choose people to go to hell because it is out of His season to move for them. What is His season? When you let Him.

So are these things coming back? Yes, they are.

Are those people getting by with it? At the moment, they are. Just like when there were no healing ministries in the land, nobody got healed. There was a long season of the dark ages when very little happened. Did it not happen because God did not want to? Did He plan the dark ages? Did He have a headache? What happened to Him? Do you think that was His plan?

It was not. It was not His plan.

People did not get healed because there was not healing available. Nobody knew about it. Nobody knew how to receive it. But it was His will to heal every person who was sick.

It is the same thing with what is coming. Is it His will for those preachers to get by with all of that, taking the sheep's money and doing what they are doing? No. But right now God does not have anything in place that He can do anything about it instantly.

But He will. Amen.

Let us look at this mercy that rejoices against judgment just a little bit as we begin to look at the qualifying things.

I think Hymenaeus and Alexander had fallen into vain jangling and endless genealogies. Paul linked them together with those who supposed that gain is godliness. It was the same group.

So let us look at a little bit of this. Last time we looked at the fact that Ananias and Sapphira went to heaven. This time let us look at the qualifying factor. Let us look at the mercy that rejoices against judgment.

I do not think there is a person in this room who might not be minorly faulted. Is that nice? Some of you are minorly faulted. Would you agree? Okay, do not agree with it. Just acknowledge it.

Some preachers think I am minorly faulted because I will not preach on the tithe and I do not like to wear suits. That just suits me.

Well, some people are a little heavier than minorly faulted. Some are severely faulted.

I was with Rick Renner over at Grace. We had not known each other too long. It was at the end of the meeting, and people were buying books and tapes. We were patiently waiting for people to get done talking between our conversation.

Finally there was a guy just standing there because you could tell he wanted time with Rick. So I gestured over to him, because Rick's back was to him. Rick turned around and said, "Yes."

The man said, "Can I ask you a question?"

Rick said, "Sure."

So I am trying to look busy over there, but I heard too much.

The guy said, "I am called to be a mighty intercessor. There is just one problem. I know this woman who prayed too much in tongues and got weird."

I tried. I tried to be nice. I decided I could not. I put our friendship in jeopardy, Rick's and mine.

I stepped up between him and Rick. Here is Rick, and here is him. I stepped up in front of Rick and faced him, with the back of my head toward Rick. I said, "Sir, if you get weird from praying too much in tongues, it is because you already were. It just dug it out where you could see it too. In fact, if you are really weird, that is about your only chance. It can get you sane."

So, "You pray too much in tongues, you will get weird."

No. I have already prayed too much, and I did not get like you are.

Sometimes you cannot evaluate things in the life they exist in. Here is this one salmon going, "Hmm, hmm, hmm." Then all of a sudden here they all come upstream: "Hmm, hmm, hmm, hmm, hmm."

"They are all wrong. They are all wrong. Where are you guys going?"

You cannot evaluate things in the life they do not exist in. Praying in tongues is your big chance to get out of that, not into it.

That is it, sir. If you get weird from praying too much in tongues, it is because you already were, and He got it out where you could see it too, not just everybody else.

Why did I say all that? Because when you talk about judgment, where is the line? If we would judge ourselves, we would not be judged. What can you get by with? Can you judge me? Can I judge you? What is it?

If you are going to qualify for something they walked in - and we will go over about four major judgments before this is done, where they were called on to turn people over - some were instantaneous.

Blindness fell on Bar-Jesus, the Jewish sorcerer, the witch. He went blind for a season, and if their season is as long as ours, he needed help for a while. But then the deputy of Paphos believed. Paul sure took care of that witch, didn't he?

How much do you want to bet? Of course, you would have to wait until you paid me off in heaven, and gold is not worth much for a commodity there. How many want to bet that he made it? I will bet you he made it. I will bet he went somewhere and repented and found out all about it. I will bet he did. I will bet what Paul did saved his eternity.

Hallelujah.

Now, you do not want to get any judgment wars going here.

I remember when I got a Baptist deacon filled with the Holy Ghost in the mill I worked in. He went back to his Baptist church, and he was a staunch deacon. Now he was a tongue-talking deacon.

So he ran out there with no wisdom and started teaching the Sunday school class that they needed to be filled and speak with tongues, and the starchy deacon was hiding behind a curtain.

They ran out and had a judgment war.

"I rebuke you in the name of Jesus."

"No, I rebuke you in the name of the Lord Jesus Christ."

"Oh, yeah? Well, I rebuke you in the name of the Lord Jesus Christ of Nazareth."

Boy, this war was horrible.

So let us understand some real basic ground-floor principles. Go to Matthew 7.

I think if we could find a clearer verse, it says, "Judge not, lest you be judged." Pretty clear?

I think I am having about as good a time as anybody else. Hallelujah.

Beginning with verse 1, I like this. These verses used to bother me. He says:

Judge not, that ye be not judged.

For with what judgment ye judge, ye shall be judged: and with what measure ye mete, it shall be measured to you again.

That is reasonable. Aren't you glad He did not say, "Heaped down, pressed together, and running over"?

Isn't this interesting? Judge not, lest you be judged. For the judgment you judge, you shall be judged. And with the measure you measure out in judgment, it shall be measured to you again.

Then the third verse says:

And why beholdest thou the mote that is in thy brother's eye, but considerest not the beam that is in thine own eye?

Or how wilt thou say to thy brother, Let me pull out the mote out of thine eye; and, behold, a beam is in thine own eye?

For some reason, this gave Him the right to call that man this:

Thou hypocrite, first cast out the beam out of thine own eye; and then shalt thou see clearly to cast out the mote out of thy brother's eye.

There are a whole lot of things I would rather be called by Jesus than a hypocrite.

So what constitutes this kind of judgment that He is talking about?

When the sinner thinks of judgment, he will remember part of one of the Ten Commandments. He will see a preacher or somebody doing something wrong, and then the preacher will tell him, "Look, you are going to go to hell."

And he will say, "Do not judge me. Do not judge me. Thou shalt not judge."

He will quote part of a verse.

But when Jesus says, "Judge not, lest you be judged," and then says the same measure you measure out in judging him will be measured back to you again, He continues by saying, "Why do you behold the splinter in your brother's eye when you have a whole beam in yours? First get the beam out of your eye, and then you can see to help your brother get the splinter out of his eye, you hypocrite."

What constitutes hypocrisy?

Hypocrisy is when you judge a brother for something you are guilty of. In the judgment He is talking about here, you hold him accountable and bring him under judgment for his fault, for what he is doing wrong to you or to other people, while you are doing exactly the same thing.

That is what constitutes hypocrisy, and that is what causes the judgment to come back on us.

Now, I can tell you, God will walk through hell with a man full of faults who needs restoring. All you have to do is hate those things as much as God does. A lot of it might end up in the trash that will be burned in the day of fire, but He will walk through hell with you over horrible things if you hate them as much as He does.

But the day you cross the line from being a believer full of faults who needs restoring to a believer under judgment who is about to get stoned is when you cross the line from being a very faulted human being into hypocrisy, by judging your brother for the same things you are guilty of.

Have you ever wondered how the next verse links together?

Verse 6 says:

Give not that which is holy unto the dogs, neither cast ye your pearls before swine, lest they trample them under their feet, and turn again and rend you.

I have heard preachers take that verse and preach it like hell was coming. I would say, "Well, what does that mean?"

They would say, "Do not tell sinners and people who are not worthy the precious things God has given."

The most precious thing I have is His blood, and I tell sinners all the time. They trample it under their feet and get mad at me.

So if we do not take "cast not that which is holy before dogs" and "neither cast your pearls before swine" out of context, what would it mean? When do you cast pearls before swine or that which is holy before dogs?

I can think of a couple of cases.

I used that chapter to write a letter for Jimmy Swaggart's comeback the first time, when he came here for a dinner with the brethren who forgave him for what he had done. I used these verses to write a letter for him about forgiveness.

Let us talk about him for a minute.

In our own self-exaltation, sometimes we get to the place where we think we are not expendable. We think we are so needed, that we are doing such a great and irreplaceable work in the body, that we are an exception.

God walked through hell with Jimmy Swaggart. He would play, and his cousins Mickey Gilley and Jerry Lee Lewis - country and rock legends - were cousins. They all had that gene. Sometimes he would play, "Oh, come on home, Jerry, come home," and just bawl. A lot of the reason for the bawling was that he knew the horrible thing that had a hold of him, but he did not know how to get it off.

So God walked through hell with him, and harvested, and harvested, and harvested, until the day he called Jim Bakker a scab on the body of Christ and judged him for the same things he himself was guilty of.

When he did, the pearl he cast before the swine was, "Thou shalt not commit adultery." That was the pearl that gave the devil the right to charge into his life and knock both of them out of the closet in full view and judgment of the whole world.

Jesus did not say you could not help them. He said, "First get the beam out of your eye, so you can see clearly how to really help them get the splinter out of theirs."

Both of you have faults. You are not going to help him by publicly destroying him. You will destroy yourself if you are not careful.

Can you have any more examples? You know I do.

In fact, one of the primary reasons in communion to examine yourself is so that you will judge yourself, so you do not have to die under the condemnation of the things the world dies under. For if we would judge ourselves, we would not be condemned with the world.

Hallelujah.

Have you got a statement? Yes.

I am going to live long and prosper and preach every day.

Hallelujah.